

Disambiguating “Scope” Across the Trilogy

Series T — Trilogy-Wide Ambiguity Reduction, Note T4.03 (#706)

Author: Wenxin Li (Independent Researcher)

ORCID: 0009-0004-8065-3235

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This work derives from and formalizes commitments across the CKS theory trilogy: “The Instinct/Reasoning Separation Outside the Model” (Li, April 2026), “Coordination Outside the Model: A Human-Governed Substrate Pattern for AI Systems” (Li, April 2026), and “Inter-Self Coordination via Shared Substrate / Full Aspect Integration” (Li, April 2026). It does not introduce new axioms. Its sole contribution is to identify and distinguish the four distinct referents the word “scope” carries across the trilogy, so that practitioners and downstream derivation notes can use the term without ambiguity.

Abstract

The word “scope” appears throughout the CKS trilogy with at least four distinct referents: an architectural tier designator, a governance authority’s territory, a FAI configuration dimension, and a convenience shorthand in these derivation notes. These meanings are not interchangeable. A statement about “governance scope” in a multi-tier architecture is a structurally different claim than a statement about “sharing scope” in an inter-Self FAI configuration, even though both use the same word. This note names the four referents precisely, maps each to the governance question it answers, and establishes that “sharing scope” — Paper 3’s FAI configuration dimension specifying which aspects a Self contributes to the shared substrate — is the operationally critical referent because it determines what governance content crosses the inter-Self perimeter.

1. Why a precise disambiguation is needed

The trilogy addresses a progressively larger coordination scope across its three papers. Paper 1 governs a single cell’s substrate. Paper 2 governs a Self at three architectural tiers. Paper 3 governs coordination across multiple Selves’ home perimeters through a temporarily constructed shared substrate. As the architecture expands, “scope” is pressed into service at each new level and accumulates referents without shedding the old ones.

Each referent corresponds to a different governance question: *what tier applies here?* (which layer's rules govern), *whose authority covers what objects?* (rights-holding), *what content participates in this event?* (inter-Self perimeter configuration), and *how architecturally complex is this paper?* (reader orientation). These questions require structurally different answers. Using "scope" loosely across contexts can silently shift referents and produce reasoning errors that look like architectural disputes but are terminological ones.

A second source of confusion is specific to these derivation notes: the phrases "at Paper 1 scope," "at Paper 2 scope," and "at Paper 3 scope" are convenience shorthands for the architectural scale and complexity level each paper addresses. This shorthand does not appear in the trilogy papers. It is introduced here to allow cross-paper comparisons to be stated concisely and must not be read as a technical governance term from the trilogy itself.

2. The four referents

Referent 1 — Tier scope (Papers 2 and 3). In the three-tier architecture Paper 2 introduces, governance operates at cell scope, aspect scope, and Self scope simultaneously. "Tier scope" names which of these levels is under discussion. Saying "at cell scope" means the commitments for a single cell's substrate are operative; "at Self scope" means the commitments for the Self's DNA and governance structure are operative. The governance question: *at which tier does the relevant rule apply?*

Referent 2 — Governance authority scope (Papers 1, 2, and 3). Each governance authority holds a territory — the set of substrate objects and orchestration rules over which it holds the three rights (inspect, modify, override). In Paper 1, one authority's scope is one cell's substrate. In Paper 2, governance authority scope is multi-shaped across three tiers. In Paper 3, it splits across the perimeter: each participating Self's home authority retains full scope over its home substrate; a joint authority (two or more Self-scope authorities operating together) holds scope over the shared substrate. The governance question: *whose authority applies, over what objects?*

Referent 3 — Sharing scope (Paper 3, FAI configuration Dimension 1). When Selves participate in a Full Aspect Integration (FAI) event, the first governance-configured dimension is which aspects each Self contributes to the shared substrate. This dimension is named "sharing scope." It is a specific technical term — not a general use of "scope" — designating the selection of which aspects participate in a given inter-Self event. When sharing scope is set, governance determines which cells' DNA-layer and action-layer content cross the inter-Self perimeter; instinct-layer content and LLM weights do not cross

regardless of this configuration. The governance question: *what content participates in this FAI event?*

Referent 4 — Scale shorthand (Series T derivation notes only). The phrases “at Paper 1 scope,” “at Paper 2 scope,” and “at Paper 3 scope” in these notes are convenience notations for architectural complexity level. “At Paper 3 scope” means: in the context of inter-Self coordination across multiple Selves’ home perimeters. This shorthand carries no governance content of its own and does not appear in the trilogy papers. The question it addresses: *how complex is the architecture under discussion?*

3. Disambiguation pitfalls

Tier scope is not governance authority scope. Tier scope names a level of the hierarchy; governance authority scope names a territory within that level. An authority at aspect scope (tier = aspect) may hold a governance territory spanning multiple aspects or only one. The tier and the authority’s reach within it are independent.

Governance authority scope is not sharing scope. A governance authority’s territory is not the same as the content contributed in a FAI event. A Self’s home authority may hold full scope over its entire home substrate while configuring a narrow sharing scope that contributes only a subset of its aspects to a given event. The authority’s territory does not shrink because the sharing scope is narrow.

Scale shorthand is not any of the above. “At Paper N scope” locates the architectural discussion; it does not substitute for tier scope, governance authority scope, or sharing scope. Reading the shorthand as a technical governance term produces misreadings of the derivation notes.

4. Sharing scope as the operationally critical referent

Among the four referents, sharing scope carries the most operational weight in inter-Self coordination contexts. The reason is precise: sharing scope is the governance configuration that determines what crosses the inter-Self perimeter.

The shared substrate spans multiple Selves’ home governance perimeters. Content within it carries provenance that crosses organizational boundaries. Everything about the inter-Self exchange — which cells’ DNA-layer and action-layer content enters the shared substrate, which operational knowledge becomes available to other participating Selves, which evolutionary material each Self can absorb afterward — follows from how sharing scope is configured. A narrow sharing scope produces a bounded exchange; a broad sharing scope produces full-aspect integration with all cells of the contributed aspects

surfaced. This is the most consequential governance decision in a FAI event because it defines the content perimeter of the exchange itself.

Tier scope and governance authority scope are structural properties that exist independently of any FAI event. Scale shorthand is a reader orientation device. Sharing scope is a per-event governance configuration that directly shapes what the FAI event produces. When reading Paper 3: if “scope” appears in the phrase “sharing scope” or in the context of configuring a FAI event, it always refers to this specific Dimension 1 configuration.

5. Disambiguation table

Usage	Referent	Governance question	Home
“sharing scope”	FAI configuration Dimension 1	What content participates in this event?	Paper 3 only
“governance authority scope”	Territory of a specific authority	Whose authority, over what objects?	Papers 1, 2, 3
“tier scope” / “at cell/aspect/Self scope”	Architectural tier designation	At which tier does this rule apply?	Papers 2, 3
“at Paper 1/2/3 scope”	Scale shorthand (derivation notes)	How complex is the context?	Series T notes only

6. Prior-art disambiguation claim

“Scope” in the CKS trilogy has four distinct referents: tier scope (the architectural level operative in a multi-tier hierarchy), governance authority scope (the territory over which a specific authority holds the three rights), sharing scope (the FAI configuration dimension specifying which aspects a Self contributes to the shared substrate for a specific inter-Self event), and a scale shorthand used in these derivation notes to indicate architectural complexity level. These referents are not interchangeable. When Paper 3 uses “sharing scope,” it always refers to FAI configuration Dimension 1 — the per-event governance decision about what content crosses the inter-Self perimeter — and not to any general sense of “scope.” When these derivation notes use “at Paper N scope,” it is a convenience notation for architectural scale, not a technical governance term from the trilogy papers. Practitioners should ask which scope question is operative before applying scope-dependent commitments: what tier? whose authority over what? what participates in

this event? how complex is this architecture? The four questions are structurally different and require structurally different answers.